substantial adjustment" and that the future of the U.S.-led global order could be contested.[1]

The BRICS experience in Bretton Woods institutions similarly challenges a second pessimistic narrative, which holds that the system is breaking down because illiberal rising powers such as China or Russia are global free-riders and cheaters, unwilling to accept existing rules and unable to construct viable alternatives. On the contrary, the BRICS reject abandoning the existing order or encouraging its breakdown in favor of a nihilistic "No One's World."[2] They want to sit at the top tables, participate in agenda-setting in the "Green Rooms," and enthusiastically pattern their own engagement and attempt to gain bargaining power based on the club model pioneered by G7. In a kind of mirror image, they blame the United States and the West for reckless leadership, alternating poor regulation of the financial system with underinvestment in Bretton Woods institutions, both approaches that risk destroying or eroding the current economic and financial order in the world. In response to Western claims that China's corruption, Moscow's crackdowns on civil society, and their overall resistance to rule of law and accountability disqualify them, the Chinese, the Russians, and others counter that the Obama administration and the newly inaugurated Donald Trump have made the same mistake in underestimating their heightened confidence and pragmatism after the United States spawned a global financial crisis while "overestimat[ing] U.S. power."[3]

In fact, although the BRICS are not unalloyed *shirkers*, they have not always played by the rules, particularly in trade, in their use of state-owned enterprises (SOEs), and with respect to the environment. Particularly in their respective regions the two authoritarian regimes in the club, especially Russia, engage in assertive, even aggressive, geoeconomic and geopolitical statecraft. Nonetheless, as discussed in Chapter 3, neither seeks to destroy the global governance order. For this reason, both have contributed to the International Monetary Fund (IMF) rescue packages and distressed developed countries' funding needs, and they also have adopted many sound financial regulations, such as Basel III, and other rules requiring transparency. Sensitive to their reputational stakes and the costs of failure, the BRICS also want their new institutions to gain legitimacy in the eyes of global market players. Consequently, they hired Western experts to write the articles of agreement for their banks, adopted transparency rules, and implemented a lean, green business model to show that they can be more